A broke demon's guide to surviving a financial crisis and finding the love of your life

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/94470306.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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KPop Demon Hunters (2025)

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Celine (KPop Demon Hunters), Rumi's Father (KPop Demon Hunters), Ryu Miyeong | Rumi's Mother, Third Sunlight Sister (KPop Demon Hunters)

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by NKret

Summary

How was it possible that finding employment in the human world was this difficult? She was a powerful demon, older than the oldest human cities, who had been enforcing the laws of Hell long before humanity had even come up with the idea of a legal code. And somehow she had ended up herein a cramped one-room apartment beneath her dignity, scraping by from payday to payday and, to make matters worse, stuck with the worst company she could possibly imagine.

Why had fate punished her so cruelly?

Or: Celine and Rumi's dad are two demons trying to survive a financial crisis on minimum wage, while Mi-yeong drags Min-j to a haunted house. What could possibly go wrong?

Notes

Hello there!

This time around, we've got the 1997 Korean financial crisis, demon roommates, and a haunted house job. This is a one-shot for now, so grab some snacks and enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

May Jeong-ho, his idiotic idea and the financial crisis be damned for eternity.

Celine worried the end of her pen between her teeth and glared at the newspaper spread across the table, fighting the urge to summon the flames of Hell—she needed the thing intact, preferably with a fresh crop of job listings tomorrow.

How was it possible that finding employment in the human world was this difficult? Ridiculous. She was a powerful demon, older than the oldest human cities, who had been enforcing the laws of Hell long before humanity had even come up with the idea of a legal code. And somehow she had ended up here—in a cramped one-room apartment beneath her dignity, scraping by from payday to payday and, to make matters worse, stuck with the worst company she could possibly imagine.

Why had fate punished her so cruelly?

"Come on, Celine, it'll be fun, Celine," she muttered, scrunching up her nose as she mimicked that insufferable demon.

At least there was some comfort in knowing that Jeong-ho lived under the exact same conditions (they did share an apartment, after all) and was, so far, losing their little job-hunting competition spectacularly.

Picking up her pen, Celine circled an advertisement for a local general store in blood-red ink. Surely it couldn't be worse than working on a fish cutter. The stench of fish still haunted her dreams.

What she wouldn't give for a trip to the bathhouse! She missed the feel of hot water washing over her skin, the scent of fragrant oils, and the pure, undisturbed peace that came with it. The shower in this miserable apartment managed lukewarm temperatures only on its best days and in winter it might as well have been fed directly from an Arctic glacier.

A shiver ran through Celine at the very thought. Thank the King for the kettle, at least. It had been her one saving grace in these wretched times.

Right. The kettle. If she didn't stumble across a good sale soon, even that tiny luxury would drift into the realm of unattainable dreams.

Suddenly, the front door flew open with enough force to slam into the wall. Celine pressed her lips into a thin line as flakes of paint showered onto the floor. Before her eyes, the image of getting her security deposit back dissolved like morning mist, leaving behind only the ghostly sensation of money that had once touched her fingers and would never return again.

"I found us a job!"

The bane of her existence, her living nightmare on two legs, a shining example of intellectual inadequacy, a source of endless misery and despair who stubbornly refused to disappear into the deepest pits of Hell, kicked off his shoes and practically shoved his face into hers.

Celine had long since given up wondering whether this walking nuisance even understood the concept of personal space.

"If it's another job as a sexton, I'll personally drown you in holy water."

"Nah." He waved a hand and finally backed away far enough that Celine no longer had to inspect the individual hairs in his eyebrows. "A new theme park is opening. They were looking for actors for a haunted house. I signed us up."

"Actors for a haunted house," she repeated, staring at the demon standing in front of her.

"Yeah. Piece of cake. I'm a demon, you're a demon. Easiest money we'll ever make."

Celine blinked. Had Beong-ho finally lost whatever scraps of common sense he had left?

"Let me get this straight. You want me to scare people in some abandoned hovel like a third-rate ghost?"

Beong-ho grinned in that idiotic way of his, showing far too many teeth.

"And they'll actually pay us for it. Ha! I bet I'll be amazing at it. My true form is practically made for the job!"

When, exactly, had Celine sunk so low that she was genuinely considering taking it?

This was the day! The glorious, wonderful day when Beong-ho would finally prove his superiority over that nagging Celine. Two thousand years of rivalry would finally end in his victory!

Excitement bubbled in his stomach, rising higher and higher and...

Okay, never mind. Apparently, the ramyeon he'd had for lunch wasn't exactly fresh.

Still, he had a feeling this was the job where he'd finally, completely defeat Celine.

He stretched both pairs of arms above his head, bent forward, straightened up, bent again, then bounced onto his toes—he had to be ready for anything. He was going to be the best. He was going to be the winner. He was the winner!

Leaning toward the mirror, he watched the living flames burning inside his eye sockets flare brighter.

"You've got this, handsome."

"Yeong-ho?" The door opened and a young woman peered inside. "You're up in five. Are you ready?"

"Born ready." Technically, he'd hatched out of an egg after his father had tried to boil it, but that was just semantics.

The girl's face paled as he flashed her his very best smile.

"G-great. Great costume," she managed before disappearing behind the door.

Oh, yes. He definitely looked great. Terrifyingly great, in fact.

With that thought, he headed for his position—a small alcove swallowed completely by darkness.

He didn't have to wait long for his first victims. Their footsteps echoed down the corridor, and judging by their laughter and general lack of concern, they were high-schoolers, or maybe freshmen.

Yeong-ho's lips stretched into a wide grin. He had never worked with the damned directly, but he was a demon, and the prospect of screams of sheer terror was like the most exquisite meal he could hope to taste in the human world. Well, except for caramel-coated peanuts. He'd definitely buy some with his first paycheck.

Suddenly, the footsteps stopped.

Yeong-ho perked up. Somewhere in the distance, hinges creaked. He couldn't hide his disappointment that they'd chosen the other route. They were supposed to come straight to him, but then again, if they ran away too soon, his boss might not be happy. Probably. He'd been a little too focused on the part where people were supposed to flee screaming at the sight of him.

The slam of a door brought him back to reality. The sound had come from a little too far away for it to be the group from earlier. Then again, fear could give people wings, so who knew? Maybe they were breaking their personal speed records right now.

He strained his hearing and—

AAAAAAaaaaaaaaaa!

The scream rang out, bouncing off metal doors and concrete walls, trembling almost like the cries of the damned. Either someone unfortunate-looking had found a mirror, or…

No.

No, it couldn't be.

Celine?

Bring, nagging Celine?

She was getting screams like that?

She?

Oh no. No, no, no.

This was not happening. He couldn't let this stand. His honor was at stake!

Yeong-ho puffed out his chest and spread all four arms to make himself look even bigger and even more terrifying. Completely ignoring the script, he set off on the hunt. There was no way he was going to let some desk jockey steal his job out from under him!

"I'd just like to point out that this is deeply unfair. I'm amazing and you're... He looked Celine up and down. "You're just... you. How on earth were you just as good? You're supposed to be a boring archivist, not a brilliant actor. It's my destiny!"

A massive crate was unceremoniously shoved into his chest.

"If a certain somebody hadn't come up with that *brilliant* idea of his, I'd still be in Hell, where I wouldn't have to worry about being unable to afford living conditions that qualify as crimes against civilization. So move your lazy ass and get back to work. For once, I'd like to eat a decent meal more than once a week." She turned away, then suddenly stopped and glanced back over her shoulder. "And I wasn't an archivist."

As if to emphasize the point, she slammed the truck door so hard the bang echoed off the surrounding buildings and sent every pigeon in the area exploding into flight. Then she spun on her heel and disappeared behind another delivery truck.

Yeong-ho adjusted his grip on the crate.

"Geez, what's with all the anger?"

He carried the package to the warehouse and set it down on the designated pallet. One quick glance at the label and, ah, that explained the weight. Did hauling an entire set of barbell plates count as going to the gym? Apparently women liked athletic men.

Heavy footsteps sounded behind the demon. Yeong-ho turned just in time to come face-to-face~~-~~or rather, face-to-something-above-face~~-~~with his employer, Mr. Lee. The man was short and it was never entirely clear who he was talking to, thanks to the eye that always seemed to look slightly off to the side.

"Have I mentioned how much I love you two?" he asked, taking a drag from his cigarette.

"Only every day since you hired us."

Mr. Lee burst out laughing, his double chin wobbling in perfect synchronization with his belly.

"For good reason, Byeong-ho." He patted the demon on the elbow because he couldn't reach any higher. "If God exists, He's watching over me. Out of everyone He could've sent, I got you two."

Byeong-ho wrinkled his nose. "Yeah, that's definitely something He'd be personally involved in."

"God works in mysterious ways," Mr. Lee agreed. "So do women. What's gotten into your friend? Is it, you know... that time of the month?"

"I'm afraid so."

Celine always became exceptionally snippy whenever bill-paying season rolled around. Byeong-ho was more than happy to let her handle all that, but she didn't have to use him as a stress-relief mechanism in the process. He ought to find a human to absorb all her frustrations instead. Yeah, that was a good idea. That way, a human would be punished for their sins (there were always some to be found), Byeong-ho could enjoy his life in peace, and everyone would be happy. (Surely there was some human masochist out there who'd enjoy the arrangement.)

"My deepest condolences," said Mr. Lee. "If you ever need some male company from someone who understands your suffering, you know where to find me."

Celine entered the warehouse carrying another crate so enormous that only her legs were visible beneath it. She dropped it into place with a thud and glared at them, murder in her eyes. For someone who wasn't an archivist, she was terrifying.

Mr. Lee took half a step backward.

“W ell, Iwont keep you, Je eong-ho,” he said, wiping his suddenly sweaty forehead with a handkerchief. “Stop by later for your paychecks. Have a nice shift.”

He turned on his heel and headed toward the office. For a man with legs that short, he moved remarkably qickly .

“Remarkable man,” the demon said, tilting his head. “Think well get rich off this crisis one day like he did?”

“Not if you keep slacking of f,” she grumbled. “Get back to work. We've still got two more trucks to unload.”

“Y es, ma'am!” He saluted. Then a brilliant idea suddenly struck him. He qickly caught up with Celine. “How about a little competition? First one to unload a truck wins. Loser buys lunch.”

“W e share a budget.”

“t' s the thought that counts!”

May Celine be damned for all eternity. At least this time, having extra arms had definitely been an advantage. And lunch tasted especially good when he wasnt the one who had to part with the money .

“Come on, hurry up!” Mi-yeong grabbed Min-j' s hand with both of hers and tugged. “Dont tell me you're washing out!”

The dimples in her friend's cheeks only made her more adorable, and whenever she flashed that crooked smile that always brought to mind those charming rogues with hearts of gold who so often

appeared on their TV. Mi-yeong felt she might melt on the spot. Min-j couldnt even deny the comparison, considering how she cried right alongside Mi-yeong during the cheesiest love confessions and even owned a jacket almost identical to one worn by a certain character . Once she became a nurse, her patients would absolutely adore her Mi-yeong just knew it.

Min-j rolled her eyes but allowed herself to be dragged along the bustling midway of the theme park. t was Friday evening and people had poured out of their homes in droves to enjoy the last warm nights before autumn's chill settled in. f not in nature, then at least in the fresh air.

"W e have until midnight. There's no need to rush."

Mi-yeong pouted.

"This is the scariest haunted house in all of Korea. Of course there' s going to be a line!"

A television crew had even come down from Seoul to film a segment about it. They'd invited mudang and other spiritual practitioners after rumors of actual ghosts started circulating, though the owner insisted it was all the work of incredibly talented actors. That didnt change the fact that Mi-yeong desperately wanted to get inside.

"Come on, hurry up. Please?"

Min-j sighed. "I spoil you way too much."She glanced over Mi-yeong's shoulder. "Can we at least get something to eat first? I havent had anything since breakfast."

And supposedly Mi-yeong was the one who never took care of herself!Changing course immediately , she pulled her friend toward the food stalls, even if her wallet cringed at the thought.

"Y ou wouldnt be hungry if you'd eaten the lunch Ibrought you."

"Mimi, I love you, but that looked like cat vomit."

"It did not!" Several passersby turned to look at them. Mi-yeong ignored them all, spun on her heel and came face-to-face with Min-ji. "Well, maybe a little, but it tasted better than it looked. You just had to close your eyes."

One of Min-ji's eyebrows rose. For a short moment they stared each other down.

"Fine." Min-ji raised her hands in surrender. "As long as your cooking keeps all those creeps away from us, I won't complain."

This time she took the lead, heading toward a corn dog stand while Mi-yeong hurried after her.

"Si-woo wasn't a creep."

"He was practically fucking you with his eyes." Min-ji bit into her corn dog, only to open her mouth almost immediately and suck in a sharp breath. "Ow, damn, that's hot."

"That's not wha—"

The words died on Mi-yeong's tongue as a bloodcurdling scream erupted somewhere in the distance. It sent birds scattering into the night sky and pedestrians came to a halt, turning toward the crooked house that stood alone at the very end of the path. The park lights didn't quite reach that far, leaving the building cloaked in shadow and lending it an even more ominous air. Under the full moon, it looked as though it had been lifted straight out of a horror film.

"Whoever that was must have incredible lungs. Are you sure—"

Whatever else Min-ji intended to say was brutally interrupted by an adorable squeak, one she would deny making until her dying day, as Mi-yeong grabbed her arm, hooked herself around it, and dragged her toward the haunted house.

"You can eat while we're in line. Let's go!"

"What? No. Mimi!"

The hour-long wait to get inside was actually pretty entertaining and nowhere near as quiet as waiting in line had any right to be. Two couples backed out at the very last minute after another piercing scream tore through the laughter and occasional shrieks that echoed through this part of the park, sounds that suddenly didn't seem loud at all.

Whoever the actors were, Mi-yeong couldn't wait to come face to face with them. Her imagination ran wild with all the possibilities for their costumes—slender, slimy, octopus-like creatures with tentacles and suckers capable of worming their way into every crack and crevice; headless, heavily muscled figures capable of snatching some poor unfortunate with one hand and pinning them to the ground until all they could do was beg; supple, unsettling shadows with velvet voices that caressed the ears and delicate hands that promised suffering and destruction; enormous—

CLAP!

Mi-yeong blinked at the sight of two hands snapping together centimeters from her nose. She was going to pretend she hadn't been the target of Min-ji's judging stare. Stupid brain and its stupid images. This had to be the internet's fault and all those dark corners that had sucked her in. Was it that vampire story she'd read?

"Please tell me you're not having one of your erotic fantasies right now."

"I have no idea what you're talking about." Mi-yeong brushed back a stray lock of hair and fanned herself with her hands. "God, it's warm tonight. Hard to believe it's already autumn, right?"

The stare didn't soften in the slightest. She needed a distraction.

The gate! The gate wasn't judging her and that was where she'd decided to focus her attention. Well, the employee standing beside it was definitely judging the people waiting in line, but that was entirely different. Maybe he had a bet going with a coworker about how many screams they'd hear tonight. It still didn't explain the beads of sweat forming on his forehead.

"I have a bad feeling about this," Min-ji muttered under her breath. She was staring at the employee too, a crease forming between her brows. "Maybe we should go on the roller coaster instead? You can scream there, too."

"No. I've already set my heart on hot monsters." "No! Wait! That wasn't how she was supposed to phrase it! "I mean, you know, it must get pretty hot under all that makeup." She laughed nervously. Min-ji's gaze might as well have been a spear piercing straight through her chest. "Oh, look! It's our turn."

They stepped inside. The door slammed shut behind them with a dull boom, cutting off every sound from the theme park. Darkness pressed in around them until Mi-yeong could barely make out anything beyond the faint reddish glow ahead. The air smelled of something remarkably similar to the artificial fog used in nightclubs.

"Wonderful. Just wonderful," Min-ji muttered. She fumbled for Mi-yeong's arm and clamped her fingers around it like a vise. "Absolutely perfect."

That might or might not have made Mi-yeong's heart flutter a little faster. Surely the house had to be haunted if simply stepping over the threshold was already having such an effect on her.

Step by step, they ventured deeper into the darkness, passing plastic skeletons and fake cobwebs, which Mi-yeong carefully brushed out of their way. The sound of violins playing a terrifying melody drifted from hidden speakers. She edged closer to her friend until she could feel the warmth of her body.

Min-j stopped so abruptly that Mi-yeong nearly walked into her . "Did you hear that?" she whispered.

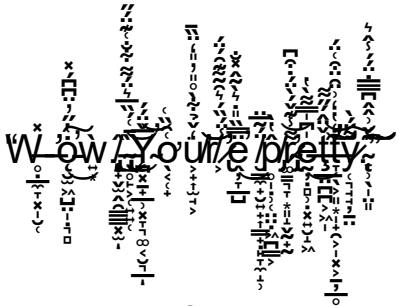
"Hear what?"

Mi-yeong strained to listen. Somewhere in the distance, a door creaked, but the music and their own heavy breathing drowned out everything else.

Suddenly, soft footsteps sounded right behind her. A watchful presence seemed to gather at the nape of her neck. Hot air, completely at odds with the chilly atmosphere of the haunted house, brushed against her skin.

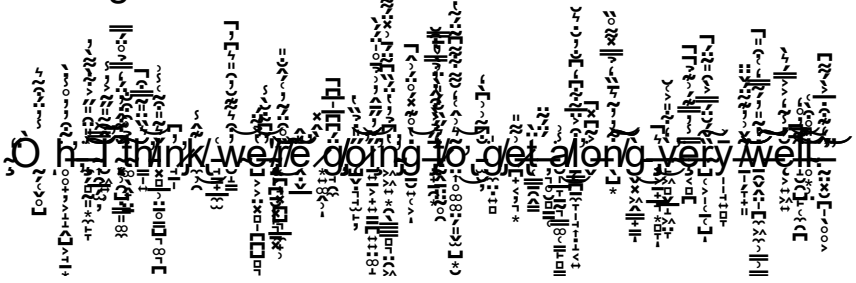
Mi-yeong swallowed. Slowly, she turned around and raised her eyes.

Two points of living fire stared straight into her soul. Lips parted, revealing fangs that gleamed in the red light. A hot breath ghosted across her face.



Mi-yeong froze. For one brief moment, her heart must have stopped beating. All she knew was that a piercing scream was ringing in her ears and the knuckles of her right hand were throbbing as though she had just punched a wall.

Another presence emerged from the darkness beside them like drifting smoke.



Another scream tore through the air. Something shot past Mi-yeong's ear and struck the figure head-on. Six pairs of eyes widened in shock.

A warm hand closed around hers and yanked. Skeletons and cobwebs flashed by in a blur of red light as they bolted. They ran and ran and ran until their lungs refused to cooperate and their legs buckled beneath their own weight.

"Fuck!" Min-j gasped once she had managed to catch her breath. "I left my shoe back there!"

End Notes

I actually came up with this idea a while ago. I'm not entirely sure if I'll expand on it yet, though I do have a few directions in mind for where the story could go. Maybe diving into the chaos of raising a half-demon child, or exploring polylight and Byeong-ho as they begin building a life together. Either way, nothing is set in stone yet.

Let me know what you think and please drop a comment if you'd like to see more of this! As always, kudos and comments are deeply appreciated.

Thanks for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!